Hari Shankar Singhania School of Business

Marketing Research Methods

An Introduction to the course

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7th Oct 2026

Can you identify this icon?





Any customer can
have a car
painted any
colour that he wants
so long as it is black

Can you identify this famous personality?



Alfred P. Sloan

The best way to serve the customer is the way the customer wants to be served







How has the paradigm changed over the years?



Era of Customer Experience

- Who are my customers?
- What do they want?
- Why have they bought my product?
  - What were they buying earlier?
- Where are they buying the product from?
- What issues do they face in buying it?
- How did they get to know about it?
- How are they using the product?
- What is their perception about the competing brands?

What is Marketing Research?

As per American Marketing Association (AMA):

The function that links the consumer, the customer, and public to the marketer through **INFORMATION**



What is Marketing Research?

Marketing research is the **systematic** and **objective**

- identification
- collection
- analysis
- dissemination
- and use of information

for the purpose of **improving decision making** related to

- identification and
- solution of problems and opportunities in marketing

What Marketing Research Is (and Isn't)

- A company tracking social media sentiment after a product launch
- A company running a structured survey before deciding whether to launch at all
- Our top-selling flavour is vanilla
- Customers say they'd pay more for a sugar-free version

Case A: The Riverside Beverage Co.

- Riverside Beverage Co. is a mid-sized regional soft drink maker whose flagship product, a citrus-ginger soda called Zest, has seen sales decline by 11% over the past two quarters.
- The VP of Marketing, Priya Nair, has been fielding angry comments on the brand's Instagram page – a recurring complaint is that the drink tastes different now and isn't as good as it used to be.
- Priya is convinced the company quietly changed its supplier of ginger extract eight months ago, and that this is the root cause.
- She wants to greenlight a reformulation project immediately: Rs. 18,00,000 to source a new supplier and rerun taste trials internally, with a target of relaunching in 10 weeks.

Case A: The Riverside Beverage Co.

- The Research Director, Thomas Alvarez, pushes back in the Monday leadership meeting. He points out:
  - Social media complaints are a tiny, self-selected sample – maybe 40 comments out of a customer base in hundreds of thousands;
  - A regional competitor, FizzPop, launched an aggressive price promotion in the same period;
  - Riverside's own distribution data shows Zest is increasingly out of stock in key convenience-store accounts; and
  - the company raised Zest's price by 6% two months before the decline started.
- Thomas proposes a two-week, Rs. 1,50,000 research sprint – a mix of a short customer survey and a review of internal sales/distribution data – before committing to the Rs. 18,00,000 reformulation.

Case A: The Riverside Beverage Co.

- Priya is frustrated.

  She tells Thomas that two weeks is two weeks the company doesn't have, that the social proof from customers is right there for everyone to see, and that asking for more research feels like stalling.
- The CEO is in the room and has to decide whose recommendation to follow before the meeting ends.

- Distinction between monitoring and structured research
- Confirmation bias
- Cost – value framework
- Multiple reasons – and acting only on one

Case B: The Bakery That Blamed the Bread

- Maple & Crumb is a six-location bakery chain in Pune.
- The owner, Daniel Deshpande, notices that weekday afternoon sales at two of his newest locations are running 30% below the chain average, despite using identical recipes, pricing, and staffing levels to his older, successful locations.
- Daniel's instinct is that something is wrong with the product at those two stores – perhaps a quality control issue with a newer oven model installed only at the new sites.
- He considers pulling the new ovens and reverting to the old equipment, a Rs. 4,00,000 expense across two stores.

Case B: The Bakery That Blamed the Bread

- His operations manager, a very practical gentleman, asks for two weeks to actually walk the two underperforming locations during the slow afternoon window.
- What he finds has nothing to do with the ovens: both new locations were built in strip malls where the only customer parking requires walking past a busy loading dock, and one location's afternoon foot traffic is blocked by a school bus pickup zone that activates at exactly 2:45–3:15pm, the chain's typical afternoon rush.
- The product was never the problem.
  - Mistaking an internal explanation for the actual cause
  - Difference between data you already have Vs research
  - Confirmation bias – towards the easiest explanation/ or an area that in control of the decision maker

Case C: The Feature Nobody Asked For

- LendWell is an early-stage fintech start-up offering a budgeting app for young professionals.
- Its founder, Marcus Shankaran, is convinced that the next big feature should be an AI-powered financial personality quiz that tells users whether they are a Saver, Spender, or Planner, with a shareable result card for social media.
- Marcus had built an early version of a similar feature at a previous company and remembers users loving it.
- He pushes the four-person engineering team to spend six weeks – nearly the entire remaining runway before the next fundraising milestone – building it.

- One engineer quietly asked a handful of existing users in casual conversation whether they'd find this useful.
- Three of five said they'd find it fun but not something they would actually use to manage money. Two asked instead for a much more mundane feature: the ability to split a recurring bill between two linked accounts.
- Nobody shared with Marcus directly, and the six-week build proceeded as planned.

- Founder's intuition substituting for research
- Opportunity cost of research
- Asymmetry between an enthusiastic minority and a need expressed quietly by multiple users

Case D: The Promotion Mistaken for Demand

- UrbanCart, a grocery delivery app, ran a one-week Free Delivery Weekend giveaway to celebrate its second anniversary, advertising heavily on local radio and Instagram. App downloads spiked by 340% during the promotional week.
- The Head of Growth, Abhay Kanwal, presented this spike to the board as evidence of strong underlying demand and proposed a $2 million Series B raise partly justified by this growth curve, with a slide titled Demand Validation: Q3 Download Surge.

Case D: The Promotion Mistaken for Demand

- A board member who previously worked in consumer analytics asked a simple question: what happened to daily active usage and order volume two weeks after the promotion ended?
- Abhay hadn't pulled that data. When he did, downloads had reverted almost entirely to pre-promotion levels, and the vast majority of promotion-week downloaders never placed a single paid order.

- Distinguishing a metric (downloads) from the underlying construct it's supposed to represent (sustainable demand)
- The danger of presenting data without research design – no comparison to a baseline or to a control period
- Vanity metrics vs. metrics tied to an actual business decision

THE RESEARCH PROCESS

Case E: The Three Months Nobody Needed

- Northbridge Telecom commissions its in-house research team to study customer attitudes toward a new family data sharing plan ahead of a planned Q3 launch.
- The research team – three analysts led by a sharp but overworked manager, Aisha Bello – spends three months designing a 1,200-person national survey, running it, and producing a 60-page report with detailed segmentation by age, income, and family size.
- Aisha presents the findings to the executive committee two weeks before the planned launch date.
- Midway through her presentation, the CFO interrupts: We already decided to launch this in Q3 regardless of what the research says – marketing has been building creative assets for six weeks.

Case E: The Three Months Nobody Needed

- Aisha learns, for the first time, that the launch decision was finalized back in month one of her research project, while her team was still in the field collecting survey responses.
- The research had no bearing on the decision it was ostensibly informing – and the budget and three months are gone.

- Research proceeded without anyone confirming that the decision was actually still open
- The cost of research misalignment, not just in money but in the credibility of the research function inside the organization
- Organizational/communication failure as a root cause of bad research, distinct from methodological flaws

Case F: Data Without a Decision

- Halsey Apparel, a fast-growing direct-to-consumer clothing brand, runs a large customer survey simply because we haven't talked to our customers in a while – there is no specific decision attached.
- The survey covers everything from favourite colours to shopping frequency to opinions on sustainability messaging, and returns over 4,000 responses.
- When the data comes back, the marketing team is excited but stuck: they have rich data and no clear question it was meant to answer, so nobody can agree on what to actually do with it.
- Three different team members propose three different, unrelated initiatives, each citing different cuts of the same dataset to support their pre-existing preference.

Case F: Data Without a Decision

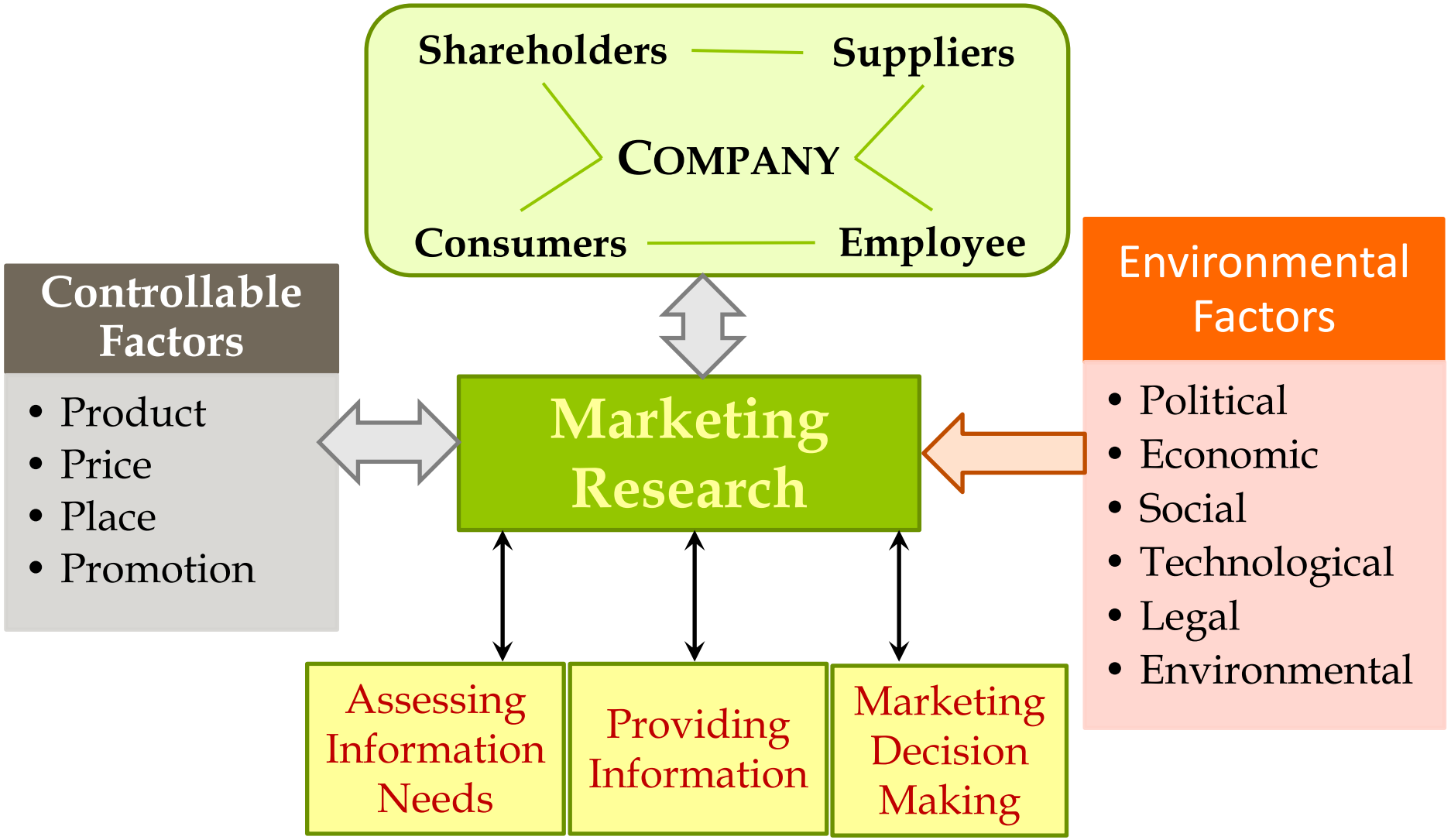
- Research without a defined decision tends to produce data that can be selectively cited to support whatever the reader already believed
- The risk of 'fishing expeditions' – broad surveys with no specific question in mind

Case G: Has QuickBite read it right?

- QuickBite, a QSR chain, introduced a new limited-time menu item in 40 of its 300 locations. Sales ⬆8% in these locations.
- VP of Menu Innovation declares the new item a clear success. Recommends national rollout. Increased traffic is the proof.
- A junior analyst points out that the 40 test locations were not randomly selected – they were chosen because they were in markets where the company had also just increased its local advertising budget for an unrelated brand campaign.
  - The traffic increase may be partly or entirely due to the advertising, not the menu item, and there's no way to separate the two effects from this data alone.

- Descriptive data showing a relationship is not the same as causal evidence that one thing caused another
- The importance of how a sample/test group is selected, not just what data is collected afterward

Role of Marketing Research



Market Research Industry in India





















Thank you